

A PODCAST REVIEW ON QURANIC METHODOLOGY

The Qur'an: A Foundation for Research and Knowledge

From Passive Reading to Active Cognitive Awareness

ولو علم الله فيهم خيرا لأسمعهم

“Had God known any good in them, He would have made them hear.”

— Sūrat al-Anfāl, 8:23

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The best podcast I have seen so far this year was between Dr. Nayef bin Nahar and Fidaa Al-Deen. It completely changed my perspective on how to engage with the Book of Allah. Below is a comprehensive summary of their profound discussion.

Many of us approach the Holy Qur'an with a sense of reverence, yet we often feel a disconnect between its verses and our modern reality. We read about ancient nations and long-past prophets, wondering how these stories relate to the complexities of the 21st century. During this exchange, Dr. Nayef explains that the problem is not in the text, but in our perception of it. To truly "open" the doors of the Qur'an, we must shift our paradigm from seeking information to building awareness.

I. The Qur'an as Methodology, Not an Encyclopedia

One of the most common mistakes is treating the Qur'an as a book of historical data. Dr. Nayef points out that the Qur'an systematically ignores details that historians prize—dates, names of fathers, exact locations, or troop numbers.

For instance, Pharaoh is mentioned over 60 times, yet we are never told his personal name or his era. In the Battle of the Trench (Al-Ahzab), the Qur'an ignores the number of camels or the names of tribal leaders, focusing instead on two pages of psychological profiling. It identifies four groups that appear in every crisis:

- The Doubters: those who believe principles are "delusions" when victory is delayed.

ما وعدنا الله ورسوله إلا غرورا

"Allah and His Messenger only promised us delusion."

— Sūrat al-Ahzāb, 33:12

- The Discouragers: those who say you cannot stay because the enemy is stronger.

يا أهل يثرب لا مقام لكم فارجعوا

"O people of Yathrib, there is no staying for you, so return."

— Sūrat al-Ahzāb, 33:13

- The Fleers: those who make excuses to withdraw.

إن بيوتنا عورة وما هي بعورة إن يريدون إلا فرارا

"Our houses are exposed, while they are not exposed. They did not intend except to flee."

— Sūrat al-Ahzāb, 33:13

- The Believers: those whose faith increases precisely when the enemy surrounds them.

ولما رأى المؤمنون الأحزاب قالوا هذا ما وعدنا الله ورسوله

"And when the believers saw the companies, they said, 'This is what Allah and His Messenger promised us.'"

— Sūrat al-Ahzāb, 33:22

By focusing on these archetypes, the Qur'an provides a methodology that remains applicable in the Algerian war, the struggle in Gaza, or any modern conflict.

II. Modeling: You Are in the Story

Dr. Nayef suggests that we should stop viewing Qur'anic figures as dead individuals and start seeing them as recurring models.

- The Pharaoh Model: represents political tyranny and the forced binding of people to a single will.
- The Qarun Model: represents the “self-made man” fallacy—those who believe their success is purely due to their own knowledge, forgetting the Divine source.
- The “Blind Man” (Surah Abasa):

عبس وتولى أن جاءه الأعمى

“He frowned and turned away, because there came to him the blind man.”

— Sūrat ‘Abasa, 80:1–2

This teaches us not to judge by formal criteria or appearances. By referring to him as “the blind man” rather than his name (Abdullah ibn Umm Maktum), the Qur'an highlights the trait that caused people to ignore him, correcting our standard for valuing humans.

- The Scholar of the Children of Israel: represents the recurring crisis of scholars “selling signs for a small price”—distorting religion to serve partisan, governmental, or banking interests.

III. The Intellectual as a “Clever Merchant”

Dr. Nayef uses a powerful analogy to describe how we should approach knowledge:

- The Regular Merchant: only sells what the market currently wants.
- The Clever Merchant: creates a culture and a need for the product.

Just as the clever merchant creates a need for their goods, an intellectual must elevate the conversation. When people ask trivia questions about the Qur'an (e.g., “How big was Noah's Ark?”), the intellectual must redirect them to “awareness” questions: “What were the cognitive barriers that prevented people from believing for 950 years?” This shift moves the Ummah from being “dazzled by data” to being “empowered by awareness.”

IV. The Condition of Engagement

The Qur'an only “interacts” with the active. If you are not concerned with justice, you will not understand the verses on justice.

- The Banking Example: a specialist in banking reform will find Qur'anic verses on contracts and ethics “snapping into place” because they are engaged with the problem.
- The Scientific Reflection: a chemist or physicist reflecting on “cosmic verses” will see treasures that a generalist would miss, such as the specific atmospheric details mentioned in the “sky’s atmosphere.”

V. Ideas vs. Terms: The Trap of Modernity

Many claim the Qur'an lacks modern theories because they look for specific jargon.

- Tyranny: you may not find the modern word for “despot,” but you find “Jabbār.” Allah is Al-Jabbār because He binds creation to His physical laws, but He explicitly allows no compulsion to ensure human conviction:

لا إكراه في الدين

“There is no compulsion in religion.”

— Sūrat al-Baqarah, 2:256

- Deterrence: the Qur'an discusses the “balance of terror” and “deterrence” through its own frameworks, even if the 21st-century political terms are absent.

VI. The Danger of Partitioning (Fragmentation)

A major barrier to sound understanding is “partitioning”—taking a verse out of context.

- The “Read” Fallacy: we often say “We are the nation of ‘Read’ (Iqra),” treating reading as a materialistic act. But the verse is:

اقرأ باسم ربك الذي خلق

“Read in the name of your Lord who created.” Reading without the Divine connection is not the Qur'anic methodology.

— Sūrat al-'Alaq, 96:1

- Selective Quoting: critics take

واقتلوهم حيث ثقفتم وهم

“kill them wherever you find them”—out of context, ignoring the preceding verse:

— Sūrat al-Baqarah, 2:191

وقاتلوا في سبيل الله الذين يقاتلونكم

“Fight in the way of Allah those who fight you”—and the follow-up clarifying that they “attacked you first.”

— Sūrat al-Baqarah, 2:190

VII. The Power of Surah Themes

Each Surah has a “compass” or a theme that governs its verses:

- Sūrat al-Baqarah — Submission: from the gnat example to the story of the Cow, the theme is submission to Divine command, even when the wisdom is “unseen.”
- Sūrat ar-Ra'd — The Intellectual Miracle: named after Thunder—a loud sound that leaves no trace—to contrast with the Qur'an, a miracle that accumulates wonders over time.
- Sūrat al-Hujurat — The Social Wall: “Hujurat” (rooms) represent the walls protecting a society. It lists direct insults (ridicule) and indirect ones (backbiting) as the destructive forces that these “walls” must prevent.
- Sūrat al-Mu'minun: mentions “turning away from ill speech” as the second trait of believers because it acts as a “safety valve” to protect one's energy from trivial challenges:

والذين هم عن اللغو معرضون

“And those who turn away from ill speech.”

— Sūrat al-Mu'minun, 23:3

VIII. Epistemology: Western Philosophy vs. the Qur'an

Dr. Nayef brilliantly contrasts the Qur'anic approach to knowledge with Western epistemology. In academic circles, epistemology heavily relies on philosophers like Francis Bacon, David Hume, René Descartes, Baruch Spinoza, and Montesquieu. While their writings open many files and expand the mind, they often leave horizons endlessly open without satisfying, grounded answers.

When you move to Sūrat an-Nahl, however, you find a completely different logic. The Qur'an clearly defines the sources, limits, and goals of knowledge. More importantly, unlike many Western philosophical traditions that often overlook this aspect, the Qur'an heavily focuses on the psychological obstacles to knowledge. It insists that you cannot separate epistemology from the human soul; all human actions, biases, and thoughts stem from psychological convictions.

IX. Psychological & Cognitive Awareness

Dr. Nayef notes that the Qur'an focuses heavily on the human soul because all fields (politics, economics, social dynamics) are driven by it.

- The Trump and the Merchant Analogy: to illustrate the psychological nature of politics, Dr. Nayef gives the example of Donald Trump's negotiation tactics. Trump often uses extremely high threats—such as threatening to impose a massive 200% customs duty—solely to rattle the opposing decision-maker. Once they are shaken, he lowers it to 100%, making it suddenly seem “reasonable.” This is the exact same psychological trick a merchant uses when asking for 100 for an item worth 20, settling at 60, and leaving the buyer feeling relieved. The Qur'an focuses on building mental toughness and psychological resilience so

that a believer—whether a political leader or an ordinary person—is not rattled or manipulated by such maneuvers.

- **Wishful vs. Demonstrative Thinking:** the Qur'an distinguishes between “desires” (wishful thinking) and “proof” (demonstrative thinking). Many political analyses today are merely “wishful,” lacking real data.
- **Scientific Denial:** referring to the philosopher Thomas Kuhn (*The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*), Dr. Nayef explains that humans often deny what they can't encompass or what they aren't used to. Modern technology (instant global communication, visual recordings) now makes the “miracles” of the afterlife, once denied by skeptics as physically impossible, seem very easy to grasp.

X. The Crisis of Trust and Sincerity

The Qur'an remains “locked” to three types of people:

- **The Lazy:** those who want a “concise book” rather than doing the research.
- **The Distrustful:** Dr. Nayef notes a severe contradiction in modern intellectuals who claim they trust the Qur'an but practically prioritize other sources. Many Muslims give immense time to philosophical and Western literature. A researcher might spend a year or two studying a specific thinker, or even specialize in them for a lifetime, knowing that to truly grasp Ibn Taymiyyah, Al-Ghazali, or Western philosophers requires years of deep study. Dr. Nayef admits he personally spent six months intensively studying Baruch Spinoza to deconstruct his cognitive material.

Yet, when these same intellectuals approach the Qur'an, they read with speed and superficiality. They will not dedicate even 10% of that time to study Sūrat Hūd, Sūrat Yūsuf, or Sūrat ar-Ra'd. Because of this rushed approach, they hastily claim, “The Qur'an has no political theory or model of knowledge,” simply because they didn't find answers instantly. We give endless time and patience to human thinkers, but deny it to the Divine source, expecting its profound depths to reveal themselves in a quick glance. How can you find nothing in the Qur'an when you haven't given it the time it deserves?

- **The Biased:** those who approach the Qur'an to find support for their pre-existing political or sectarian stances.

XI. Practical Steps for a Different Ramadan

To move from a formal relationship to a cognitive one:

- **The 10-Word Rule:** learn the meaning of 10 new Qur'anic words this month. In 20 years, you will have a vocabulary of 200 concepts.
- **Surah Branding:** choose one Surah and “own” it. Identify its theme and express its lessons in your own words.

- Trait Auditing: collect the traits of the “Hypocrites” from Sūrat al-Munāfiqūn or at-Tawbah and perform a self-audit: “Which of these traits do I suffer from?”

XII. Conclusion: Sincerity as the Key

Ultimately, the Qur'an is a profoundly layered text that requires sincere intention to unlock. Dr. Nayef concludes that opening the door to reflection is the only “safety valve” against those who tamper with the text. If we impoverish the Ummah's awareness, we leave them vulnerable to shallow fallacies. If we approach the Qur'an with a “pure heart,” seeking guidance out of darkness, the doors will inevitably open.

As the verse says:

ولو علم الله فيهم خيرا لأسمعهم

“Had God known any good in them, He would have made them hear.”

— Sūrat al-Anfāl, 8:23

Go as I recommend and watch the full video on the YouTube channel of Fidaa Al-Deen.

Ramadanukum Mubarak, Ma'a as-Salāmah, Fī Amānillāh.

About the Author

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Sibiyan Updulrauf is a writer and researcher on Islamic spirituality and philosophy. He writes on Substack about Islamic psychology, technology, and book and podcast reviews, engaging classical Islamic scholarship alongside cross-disciplinary literary and philosophical works.